

Argos and the Lost Keepsake

The windswept shores of Troy stretch along a bright Aegean sea, where wooden ships with painted eyes lie beached on the long sand and a great city of honey-coloured walls stands proud on the hill above. For a long while two camps, the weary seafarers on the beach and the proud city behind its gates, have been caught in a tired old quarrel that neither truly wants. Across the wine-dark sea lies the long road home, full of wonders: a loyal old hound, a keeper of the winds, and lonely sea-singers on the rocks. Here a hero is not the strongest or the loudest, but the one who is brave, loyal, and full of ideas. The grandest deeds are done not with spears but with a good idea and a kind heart, and the oldest quarrels often end with a single brave act of friendship.

The answers are here. This part is for the grown-up, not for the child.

Show the matching picture in the Atlas as you reach each place.



Read aloud, slowly and warmly. Stop often to let the children answer. There are no wrong answers here, only brave new ideas to try.

Before you begin

The ships are nearly ready to sail home across the sea. There is happy bustle all along the Ship Camp, with sails being mended and figs being packed. But near one tent sits your friend Lykos, and he is crying.

"I have lost my keepsake," he says. "A little token, carved from olive wood, that my grandmother gave me. I carried it all this long way, and now it is gone, somewhere out on the windswept shore. We sail at sunset. I cannot leave it behind."

Odysseus the Bright kneels beside you. "A friend is sad, and a treasure is lost," he says. "That is a job for bright ideas and faithful hearts. Will you go and find it before the ships sail?"

He gives you three gifts: the Conch Horn, the Basket of Honey and Figs, and Penelope's Thread. Then he whistles, and up trots a loyal old dog with a grey muzzle and a wagging tail.

"This is Argos the Faithful Hound," says Odysseus. "He never forgets a friend or a scent. Follow his nose, follow each other, and leave no one behind."



What is your hero name? Will you be a hero of Imagination, of Courage, or of Loyalty?

Stop 1 Following Argos

Argos puts his nose to the sand and sets off along the beach. He stops at a little mark in the sand, then at another, then he looks back at you and waits.

There are tracks here, and small clues too: a dropped fig, a footprint, a scuff where someone sat down to rest.



What could you do? Could you look closely at the tracks with Argos and read which way your friend walked? Which clues point one way, and which point the other?

When you follow the right trail, Argos gives a happy little bark and trots on. You are on the scent now.

Stop 2 The Tide Pools

The trail leads you in among the sunlit rock pools, where the sea has left little ponds full of shells and crabs. The keepsake brushed past one of these pools, but which one?

There are three pools. Beside the first lies a white shell. Beside the second lies a striped shell. Beside the third lies a smooth grey pebble.

Argos sniffs and tells you two things. The scent went past a striped shell, not a white one. And the scent did not stop where the pebble was.



Can you remember the clues? Which pool had the striped shell and no pebble? That is where your friend rested, and dropped a thread from his cloak.

When you work out the second pool, you find the thread caught on a rock, pointing the way on. Argos wags his tail. Well thought!

Stop 3 The Far Dune

The trail ends at a lonely dune, far along the shore, where the wind has been piling the sand all day. Somewhere here the keepsake fell, and the wind has half buried it.

Argos sniffs in big circles, then stops at one spot and looks at you, ears up.



What could you do? Could you watch where Argos points his nose and dig there, very gently, together? Look for a corner of olive wood in the sand.

When you brush the sand away, there it is: the little carved token, warm from the sun. Argos digs the last of it free with one careful paw and drops it into your hands.

Nobody Left Behind

You hurry back along the shore to the Ship Camp, the keepsake held safe. When Lykos sees it, his face lights up like the sunrise.

"You found it! You came back for it!" he cries, and he hugs the little token, and then he hugs Argos, who wags so hard he nearly falls over.

Odysseus the Bright smiles and says, "You did not leave a friend behind. That is the best idea there ever was." Out on the bright waves, Thetis the Sea-Mother lifts her gentle face and smiles upon you.

The ships can sail home now, every friend and every treasure safe aboard. Well done, heroes. Well done, Argos. Nobody was left behind.

Argos and the Lost Keepsake: Rules for the Grown-Up

The Guide for the Grown-Up explains how the game works; read it once and you are set. This page holds only what is special about this story. A failed roll is never a defeat; nobody loses. This is a gentle, kindly tale: there is no fight in it at all, only a lost treasure, a sad friend, and a faithful dog to help you put things right.

Setting up

- Print the map. Each player puts a small figure on the Start, the Ship Camp.
- This world has no magic. Instead each hero leans on one or two of the five qualities: **Imagination** (dreaming up ideas), **Courage** (a steady heart), **Loyalty** (standing by a friend), **Cleverness** (a clever, kind idea), or **Patience** (waiting and trying again). On the hero sheet, where it says magic, let each child write the quality they like best. Two different qualities work best together.
- Give each player five energy stars (five small tokens or bricks). They are spent and refilled during play.
- Set out three props if you can: any seashell for the Conch Horn, a small cake or token for the Basket of Honey and Figs, and a ball of string for Penelope's Thread. Anything can be anything.
- Keep your dice and the dice-band table from the back of the kit beside you.

The Twist of Fate

Once at each place the players may roll for a twist; read the matching line. The Guide explains how it works.

Roll	Twist of Fate
1	Odysseus the Bright gives you one free hint.
2	You find your second wind, and take back one energy star.
3	A fair wind off the sea, and the next challenge is Easy.
4	Argos the Faithful Hound trots up and wags his tail. All is well.
5	A basket of figs for luck: keep one roll to use again later.
6	A warm sea breeze, and for a moment everyone feels brave.

How it ends

There is no foe in this story and no fight to win. The challenge is simply to keep faith with a friend: to follow Argos, read the clues, remember carefully, and not give up until the lost keepsake is found and carried home. Let the reunion land, the friend overjoyed, Argos praised, Thetis the Sea-Mother smiling on the calm sea; it is the whole point. See the puzzles page for the three stops and their solutions.

Argos and the Lost Keepsake: Puzzles and Solutions

For your eyes, not the children's. Each stop lists its band, what the players need to work out, the intended solution, and a gentle fallback so a stuck child always moves forward. More than one good idea should work; reward imagination and loyalty over the "right" answer.

Stop 1: Following Argos (Easy)

The challenge. Argos has the scent, but the players must read the tracks and clues along the shore to choose which way their friend walked. Some marks lead onward; some lead nowhere.

Intended solution. This is a moment of Observation and Loyalty. Have the children look closely with Argos and sort the clues: the footprints that carry on in one clear direction, the dropped fig and the resting scuff that sit along that same line, against any stray marks that double back or peter out. Following the clues that agree with one another, and trusting Argos when he barks happily, sends them the right way. Any child who slows down, looks carefully, and stays on the trail has solved it.

Fallback. If they are unsure, let Argos take a few steps the right way and look back, or let them spend an energy star to "look again" and notice that the deep, onward footprints all point the same way. Sticking close to the dog and not giving up always finds the trail; this stop is meant to feel like an easy, happy start.

Make it simpler. Lay out two paper paw prints and ask a little one to walk along them on tiptoe like Argos, following the trail together.

Stop 2: The Tide Pools (Normal)

The challenge. The trail leads in among three sunlit tide pools, and the players must work out which pool their friend rested beside, where a thread slipped from his cloak.

The worked example. Read the scene so the three pools are clear. Beside **pool one** lies a white shell. Beside **pool two** lies a striped shell. Beside **pool three** lies a smooth grey pebble. Argos gives two clues to hold in mind at once: the scent **passed a striped shell** (so not the white-shell pool), and the scent **did not stop where the pebble was** (so not the pebble pool). Cross off pool one and pool three, and only **pool two**, the striped-shell pool with no pebble, is left. That is where the dropped thread is found, pointing the way on.

Intended solution. This is a Memory, Logic and Observation moment. The bright move is to remember both of Argos's clues and use them to rule pools out one at a time until a single pool remains. Counting on fingers, pointing at each pool in turn, or laying a token by each one as they reason are all good.

Fallback. If the children lose the thread of it, simplify to one clue at a time: "Argos says not the white shell, so which pools are left?" then "Argos says not the pebble, so which one is it?" Or let them spend an energy star while Argos sniffs straight to the right pool. Reaching pool two by any route counts as a full success and tops up an energy star.

Make it simpler. Set out three cups and hide a shell under one, then let a little one peek and point to the cup that has the striped shell beside it.

Stop 3: The Far Dune (Normal)

The challenge. The keepsake has fallen near a lonely dune and the wind has half buried it in the sand. Argos finds the spot; the players must dig it out gently and reunite their friend with it.

Intended solution. This is an Observation and Loyalty moment. The bright, kind move is to watch where Argos points his nose, kneel at that exact spot, and dig carefully together,

brushing the sand away a little at a time and watching for a corner of olive wood rather than scrabbling and scattering it. When they do, the carved token comes up warm and whole, and Argos frees the last of it with one gentle paw. Patience and care, not force, win the day.

Fallback. If a child digs in the wrong place or grows frustrated, have Argos pad over, sniff once, and start the digging himself right where it should be, so they can join in. Spending an energy star to "look closer" also reveals the glint of wood. The keepsake is always found; the only question is how tenderly.

Make it simpler. Hide a small toy under a cushion and let a little one brush it away gently with one hand to find the treasure and give it a hug.

The ending

There is no battle and no loser. When the keepsake is carried home, Lykos is overjoyed and hugs both the token and Argos, Odysseus the Bright praises the heroes for leaving no one behind, and **Thetis the Sea-Mother** smiles on the calm sea so the ships may sail home with every friend and treasure safe aboard. The heroes have won the only way anyone wins here, by being brave, loyal, and full of ideas.

Wander and Tales

Tale Book

<https://github.com/agigante80/wander-and-tales>

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Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.